Physical Punishment Is Not a Developmental Necessity

Prospective syntheses associate spanking with worse child behavior and find no reliable positive developmental benefit; this is not a claim that every instance produces a damaged child.

MODERATE-TO-HIGH-NOT-NECESSARY; MODERATE-EFFECT-SIZE | STATUS: DRAFT | DOMAIN: BEHAVIOR, FAMILY | REPLICATION: V

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

Physical punishment (spanking and related acts) is consistently associated with poorer behavioral outcomes in prospective research. Gershoff & Grogan-Kaylor (2016) meta-analyzed spanking and child outcomes and found no evidence of a reliable positive developmental benefit, with associations in the direction of more, not fewer, behavior problems. The identification is stronger as "not necessary / not beneficial" than as a precise universal causal effect size.

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

Prospective longitudinal studies, cross-lagged models, and meta-analysis. Child behavior can evoke harsh responses (child-to-parent). A later contrary meta-analysis arguing near-zero average effects of "customary spanking" is a live identification dispute; it does not establish developmental benefit. This card does not reopen sleep-training or attachment-intervention theory.

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

Many associations are small in cross-lagged analyses. Consistency of direction and absence of demonstrated benefit matter more than a portable d. Effects may accumulate with frequency and severity.

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

GI attenuation: partially confounded (20–50%) (child aggressive temperament evokes parental harshness; twin-differences models show persistent negative associations after genetic control).

Cultural normativeness may moderate, but does not convert spanking into a developmental requirement.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

Does not mean every parent who has used physical punishment will produce a damaged child. Does not mean all nonphysical consequences are harmless. Does not mean toddlers' failed inhibition (Chapter 11) is a moral failure requiring force.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Physical punishment should not be recommended as an evidence-based developmental tool. Institutional responses should pair limits with practical support, not parent-blaming.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Gershoff & Grogan-Kaylor (2016), Journal of Family Psychology